

S01-R — Week 1 Review: The New York Playing Field

Summary

This handout closes the course's first week with a synthesis of the five lessons delivered between August 8 and August 12, 2026: the circuit a work of art travels through, the scale gap between New York's three auction houses, the mechanics separating the hammer price from what a buyer actually pays, the distinction between the primary and secondary markets, and three cases showing how institutional recognition relates to auction price. It closes with a practical guide to the calendar's next major date, the Armory Show in September.

1. The circuit and the scale of the global market

A work of art moves through five stations. Galleries, the primary market, sell a represented artist's work for the first time. Auction houses, the secondary market, handle resale. Fairs compress the primary market into a single week, museums do not sell but validate, and advisors guide the buyer through each step. According to the *Art Basel and UBS Global Art Market Report 2026*, by economist Clare McAndrew, dealers and galleries generated [\\$34.8 billion in global sales in 2025](#), close to 58% of the total market, against \$20.7 billion in public auctions and under \$4.2 billion in private sales reported by the auction houses themselves.¹ The United States accounted for 44% of global value that year, about \$26 billion, confirming New York as the system's central hub.¹

2. New York's three houses: the structural gap

The final 2025 balance sheets, published between November 2025 and January 2026, show a stable hierarchy among the three houses operating the secondary market in the city. Sotheby's projected [consolidated global sales of \\$7 billion](#), up 17% over 2024 and the house's best result in its history.² Christie's closed the year at \$6.2 billion, 7% above 2024.³ Phillips reported [\\$927 million in global sales](#), up 10% year over year.⁴ The ratio, between 6.7 and 7.5 times more revenue for the two larger houses, stayed almost unchanged from 2024, a sign of a structural difference rather than a one-year fluctuation. Phillips offsets that gap by competing on selection: on May 19, 2026, it sold 100% of the lots in its

Modern & Contemporary Art Evening Sale, [a "white glove" sale totaling \\$115.2 million](#), more than double the same week in 2025.⁵

3. The mechanics of an auction: from estimate to purchase price

Three numbers govern an auction transaction and rarely match. The estimate is a range calculated by specialists and published in the catalog. The reserve is the confidential floor the consignor negotiates with the house, usually set at or below the low estimate. The hammer price is the winning bid accepted by the auctioneer, and it is not what the buyer pays: the buyer's premium stacks on top in tiers, per [Phillips's Buyer's Premium Rates](#), in effect in New York since April 12, 2026, at 29% up to \$2,000,000, 22% between \$2,000,000 and \$8,000,000, and 15% above that.⁶ Applied to a \$500,000 hammer, the purchase price comes to \$645,000 before taxes. The same logic separates the evening sale, curated and higher profile, from the day sale, with more lots and a slightly lower sell-through rate: Phillips's Morning and Afternoon sessions on May 21, 2026, added [\\$30,542,170](#) to the previous night's \$115,216,700.⁷

4. Galleries and fairs: the primary market and September's calendar

The line between primary and secondary market grew blurrier as large galleries began operating their own resale units. The most cited case is Perrotin, which created Second Marché, dedicated exclusively to the secondary market, after its co-directors noticed that even major collectors received split attention, one person selling them new work, another handling purchases or resales of work already in circulation.⁸ In the primary market, price discipline also matters: Marc Glimcher, president of Pace Gallery, explained that the gallery [adjusts young artists' prices in increments of roughly 10% a year](#) to protect their careers.⁹ The calendar's next date is [The Armory Show, confirmed for September 24 through 27, 2026, at the Javits Center](#), the semester's first major gathering after the August lull and an early read on demand ahead of the November sales.
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5. Institutions and price: three distinct sequences

The relationship between institutional recognition and auction price does not follow a single order. Olga de Amaral's retrospective at the Fondation Cartier preceded by about a year the record for her piece [Pueblo H, sold by Christie's on November 19, 2025, for \\$3,125,000](#), more than double her previous high.¹¹ With Frida Kahlo the order reversed: the record for [El sueño \(La cama\), sold by Sotheby's on November 20, 2025, for \\$54,660,000](#), preceded *Frida and Diego*:

The Last Dream at MoMA.^{12 13} Julio Le Parc shows a third scenario, the institutional signal without a match yet: his Tate Modern retrospective did not move his auction record, still set at \$506,500 since 2010.^{14 15} For a client who talks about art as an investment, it is worth recalling that, per Deloitte Private and ArtTactic, the Artnet Fine Art Top 100 index returned just 3.2% annualized over twenty years, against 10.4% for the S&P 500.¹⁶

For the client conversation

- The scale gap between Christie's, Sotheby's and Phillips is not an argument against the latter: for an artist whose market is still forming, Phillips's selection strategy has concrete results to show.
- Asked what a lot will really cost, the professional answer always adds the tiered buyer's premium to the hammer price, never quotes the hammer as the final number.
- Before a retrospective for an artist a client follows, it is worth distinguishing whether institutional recognition has already translated into price or not yet.

References

Methodological note: for the fourth consecutive day, the fetch tool was completely blocked for every external domain tested today (momaps1.org, theartnewspaper.com, en.wikipedia.org, all returning EGRESS_BLOCKED), while WebSearch worked normally. Since today's entry is a review of week 1 and introduces no new data, this handout was built exclusively from figures and URLs already cited and verified in the S01-L1 through S01-L5 handouts (2026-08-08 through 2026-08-12) and in curso/fuentes/dossier-05-calendario.md, all verified on 2026-08-08, with no new unverified URL added today.

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